B · RELATIONSHIPS & COUPLES

The Four Horsemen & Their Antidotes

Based on the research of Dr. John Gottman (Gottman Method). An independent summary, not affiliated with The Gottman Institute.

1 WHAT IS IT?

The "Four Horsemen" is psychologist John Gottman's name for four communication patterns (criticism, contempt, defensiveness, and stonewalling) that his research found predict relationship distress and breakup. Each has an antidote: a learnable skill that keeps partners connected during conflict.

2 HOW DOES IT WORK?

HORSEMAN	ANTIDOTE
Criticism *"You never think about anyone but yourself."*	**Gentle start-up** *"I felt hurt when plans changed. Can we check in first next time?"*
Contempt Mockery, eye-rolling, disgust: *"Wow, you can't handle anything."*	**Appreciation & respect** *"I know this week's been a lot. Thank you for handling dinner."*
Defensiveness Excuses or counterattack: *"Well, I wouldn't have to if you..."*	**Take responsibility** *"You're right, I forgot. I'm sorry. I'll set a reminder."*
Stonewalling Shutting down, going silent, turning away	**Physiological self-soothing** *"I'm flooded. Can we take 20 minutes and come back to this?"*

Horsemen and antidotes as described by Gottman; example phrases are original.

3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

These patterns tend to show up when we feel hurt, unheard, or overwhelmed. They're protective moves, and nearly every couple uses them sometimes. What matters is how often they appear and whether they get repaired.

Gottman's research identified contempt as the most damaging of the four. Stonewalling often happens when someone is physiologically "flooded," with heart racing and body in fight-or-flight, which makes listening truly hard. Taking a break then isn't avoidance; it makes the next conversation possible.

Safety first. These skills are for everyday conflict. If you feel afraid of your partner, or there are threats, control, or violence, please reach out for support. In the U.S., the National Domestic Violence Hotline is 1-800-799-7233.

4 WHAT CAN HELP?

Start gently

Describe the situation and your feeling, then name a positive need: "I feel ___ about ___, and I need ___." A complaint about a situation lands very differently from criticism of a person.

Catch it and repair

Notice a horseman in the moment and try a repair: "Let me try that again," or "You're right about that part." Repair matters more than getting it perfect.

Pause when flooded

Agree on a signal for breaks. Take at least 20 minutes doing something soothing (not rehearsing the argument), then come back to the conversation.

5 REFLECTION QUESTION

Which horseman shows up most for you when you feel hurt, and what might it be protecting?

6 KEY TAKEAWAY

Conflict isn't the problem; how we fight and how we repair shapes the relationship.

7 REFERENCES

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